

Canning Timeline Puzzle

Category	Sequencing puzzle - Hands-on - Table engagement
Skill level	Some prep to print and cut the step cards; easy to run. The correct order is the real OSU recipe sequence - players self-check using the step numbers on the back, or you use the Answer Key.
Audience	All ages - a Kids deck (simple steps) and a Teen/Adult deck (full technical steps) for each process. Pick the deck that fits the player.
Setup time	10-15 minutes (printing and cutting)

DESCRIPTION

Players put the steps of a real food-preservation process in the correct order. Six processes (strawberry jam, whole tomatoes, pressure-canned green beans, refrigerator pickles, freezing vegetables, fruit preserves), each as a Kids deck and a Teen/Adult deck. Steps come from the exact OSU-recommended sequence; safety-critical steps are flagged. Players order the cards, then flip them to self-check the numbers on the back.

MATERIALS NEEDED

Digital version (tablet)

- A tablet open to the puzzle: sign in to the MFP Volunteer Resource Hub, tap "Toolkit," then "Play on tablet" on the Canning Timeline Puzzle card. Choose the process and the Kids or Teen/Adult version, then tap the steps in order.

Printed version (no technology needed)

- One puzzle deck per process and age: "puzzle-<process>-kids.pdf" and "puzzle-<process>-adult.pdf". The front of each card is a step; the back has only the step NUMBER for self-checking. Print the decks you want and cut the cards apart.
- The "Answer Keys" (answer-keys.pdf) - the correct order for every process.

Both versions

- Table and MFP / OSU Extension signage; optional take-home educational handouts.
- This Activity Guide on the table.

SETUP

1. Pick the processes and ages you expect. Print those decks and cut the cards apart; keep each deck together (a rubber band and a label help).
2. Print the Answer Keys for yourself.
3. Digital: open the puzzle and pick a process and version to try.

ACTIVITY DIRECTIONS

Running it (printed)

1. Hand the player a shuffled deck for their age (Kids or Teen/Adult).
2. Ask them to lay the step cards out in the order the process happens.
3. When they are done, have them flip the cards over: the numbers on the back should read 1, 2, 3 ... in order.
4. Talk through any steps they reordered - especially the SAFETY steps (marked with a red border) and why order matters.

Running it (digital)

1. Choose the process and the Kids or Teen/Adult version.
2. The player taps the steps one at a time in the order they think is right.
3. The puzzle shows which steps landed in the correct spot (green) and where each should go.

VOLUNTEER NOTES

- The order is the actual OSU-recommended sequence - use the Answer Keys to confirm; do not improvise the order.
- SAFETY steps have a red border (boiling water, pressure, acid, headspace, processing time). Point these out - getting them right matters most.
- Match the deck to the player: Kids deck for younger children, Teen/Adult deck for older players who can handle the full technical steps.
- This is about learning the sequence, not performing canning - keep it a friendly puzzle and refer hands-on "how do I can this?" questions to a Master Food Preserver.
- No tablet? The printed decks play exactly the same.
- There are no prizes - finishing the timeline and the conversation are the reward.